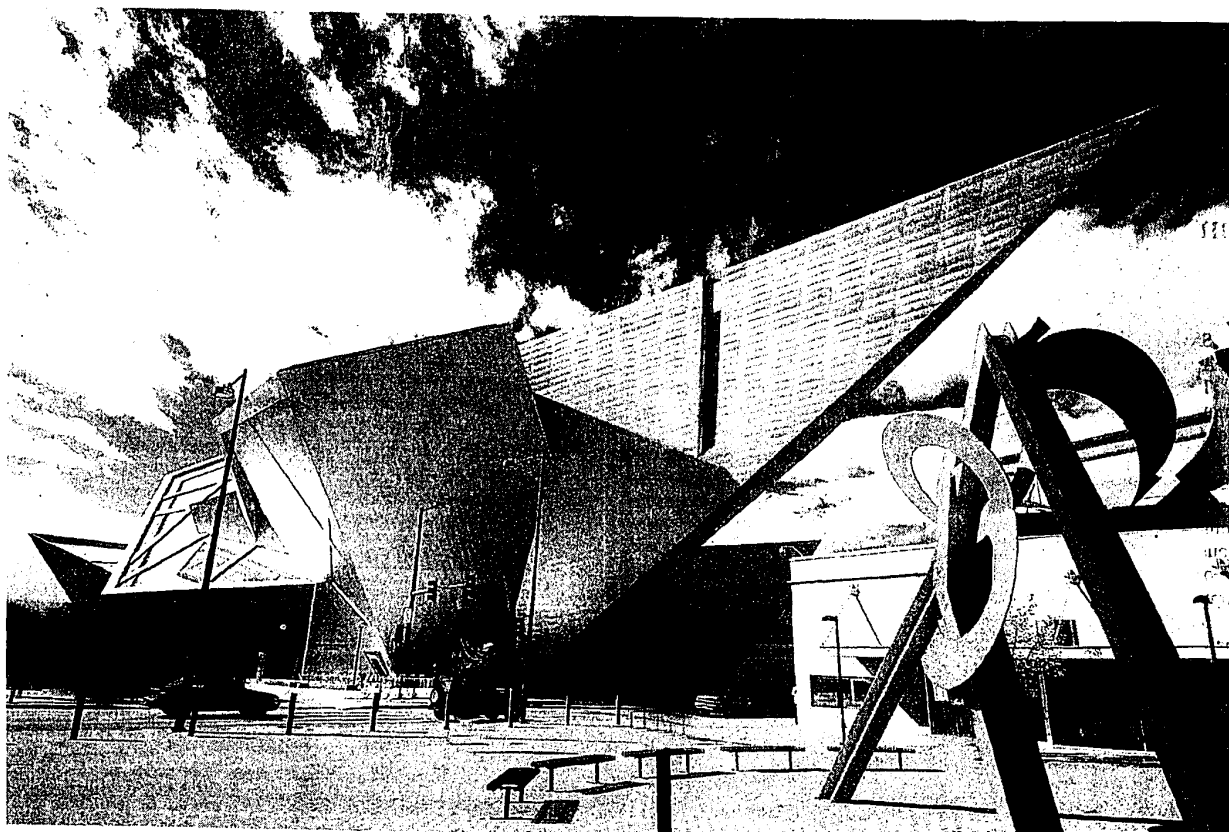




STEVE CRECELIUS

Daniel Libeskind's Hamilton Building at the Denver Art Museum is a pile of shapes and angles, sheathed in glittering titanium.

Denver hits a high point

Daniel Libeskind designs an exhilarating wing for the city's art museum

By Robert Campbell
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

DENVER — Before I came here, I was ready to dismiss the new Denver Art Museum as a show-off piece of architecture, one of those buildings that feels like a chapel where you are supposed to worship the ego of some over-hyped architect.

DAM is certainly a vivid, look-at-me sculptural object. It resembles a frozen explosion. It's a big loose pile of shapes and angles, all sheathed in glittering titanium, the material of Frank Gehry's famous Guggenheim Museum in Spain.

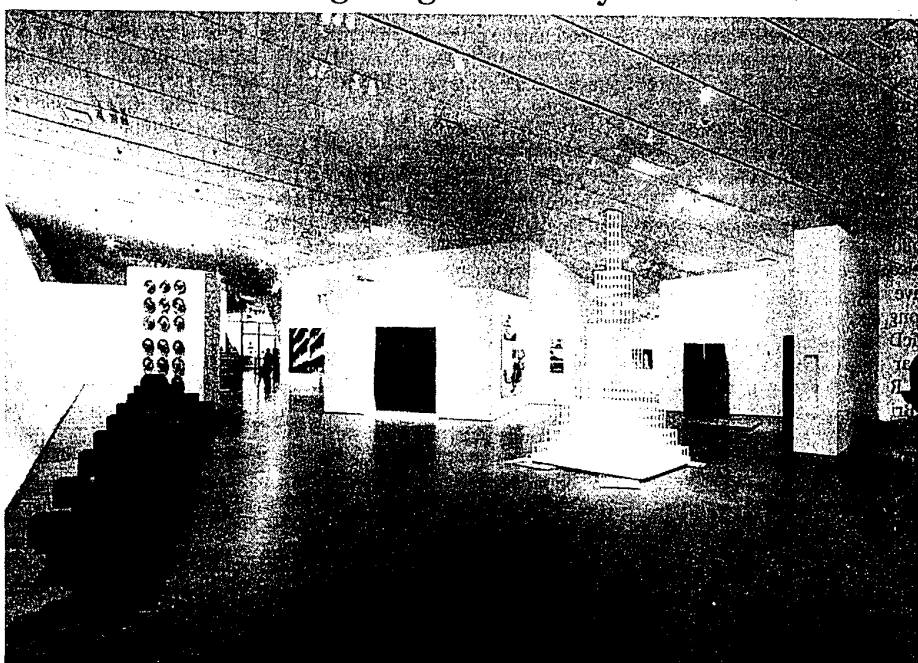
As you'd expect from the exterior, the interior is a kind of fun house of sloping walls and angled spaces. You'd think it would overwhelm the artworks it's supposed to be displaying. But it doesn't. I wandered the galleries with a growing sense of excitement and delight. DAM is a wonderful building.

It's a \$90 million new wing, to be precise, of the Denver Art Museum, which still occupies a 1971 building by a noted Italian designer of the era, Gio Ponti. The two are connected by a glass bridge. The wing's proper name is the Hamilton Building, but we'll call it DAM for short, while remembering that it's part of a larger whole.

DAM's architect is Daniel Libeskind. Libeskind is famous or infamous, depending on your point of view, for having won a design competition for the World Trade Center site in New York, where he proposed a 1,776-foot tower. Since then he's been muscled out of the WTC job by money and politics. But the competition made him famous, and today he's designing buildings all over the world.

Denver, though, wasn't impressed by Libeskind's fame. The museum chose him as its architect before his WTC notoriety, at a time when he'd built little. It must have felt like a scarily bold move, but it turned out to be the right one.

"We told Daniel that we wanted a signature building, one that would make the whole world come to Denver," says Lewis Sharp, the museum's director. "And we wanted you to be able to



JEFF WELLS

Inside the museum's new wing, Libeskind has designed long vistas that pull you forward and upward and odd corners turn you aside to view some intimate setting.

look up and see all the floors."

The best way to explain the exhilaration of DAM is to compare it with another new museum, the Museum of Modern Art in New York. MoMA is a boring, confusing, and repetitious maze of identical white walls. Bathed in white light, the walls look like movie screens, and they make the paintings look like slide projections. Nothing feels substantial. Paintings, like people, need places to inhabit, not vague atmospheres to float in, and MoMA fails to create a sense of place.

Creating place is what DAM does best. The museum is constantly unfolding spatially as you move through it. Long vistas pull you forward and upward. Odd corners turn you aside to view some intimate setting. Spaces are tall or low, distant or near, ever changing. In some ways it's more like a landscape than a conventional interior. It's as if you were climbing among tilted rocks and cliffs. "Right-angled galleries look antiquated," says director Sharp.

There's nothing particularly

original here. Free-form interiors like this go back at least to Gehry's Vitra Design Museum of 1989 in Germany. Libeskind has simply taken a well-known architectural language and used it to write a better poem.

For the museum's curators, the interior certainly offers a challenge. How do you hang a painting on a wall that appears to be falling toward you? Part of the fun of DAM is to notice the ingenious ways that problem has been solved. Again unlike MoMA, there's something delightfully ad hoc about the ways in which curators find the exactly right place for each artwork. They respond to the fact that they have a choice of places, not a repetition. They marry each work to its setting.

Frank Lloyd Wright's great Guggenheim in New York, one remembers, is also made of sloping walls and ramps. As you look up through DAM's central atrium, where galleries pile up on the sides like opera balconies, you realize Wright's museum was another inspiration here.

Libeskind, it's important to note, did not arrange the many interior partitions that divide up DAM's galleries. At the museum's request, he provided big, empty, loft-like spaces. Within these an exhibition designer, Dan Kohl, worked with the curators to create the marvelous arrangement that's currently in place. The partitions can be rearranged whenever desired. Choice and change, once again, are the motifs.

Up to now, I've never been a fan of Libeskind's architecture. Many people find his Jewish Museum in Berlin to be emotionally moving, but it isn't good architecture. His War Museum in Manchester, England, is worse, although that's partly the result of huge budget cuts. DAM is a quantum leap above these. Not only is it brilliantly conceived, it's well detailed, partly the work of the Davis Partnership, the Denver architects who worked with Libeskind.

Nothing is perfect. The entry lobby looks like a showroom for

ugly black sofas. And although the interior lighting is very well done, it's too bad that the museum told Libeskind it didn't want natural daylight in the galleries. He sneaks some in here and there, but more would be welcome. One thinks of the great light in museums by the architect Louis Kahn.

Outside, DAM is a handsome object, beautifully set among big sculptures by Beverly Pepper, Mark di Suvero, Claes Oldenburg, and others. DAM looks fine by itself. But it stands in an uninspiring civic ghetto of museums and government buildings. Instead of pleasant, active streets and squares, you get shapeless lawns and plazas. Some of it is OK, but there's a sense of too much open space, a touristy setting in which the buildings stand around like pavilions in a world's fair. A museum for the work of American painter Clifford Still will some day rise right beside DAM.

Across from DAM, Libeskind has designed a handsome row of condos with shops on the ground floor. They contribute some life, and they conceal a parking garage, but the buzz of urbanism isn't quite here yet.

The architecture of DAM has received a pretty bad rap from commentators and critics. Everyone has the right to an opinion. I wonder, though, if critics aren't miffed by the fact that they didn't discover Libeskind themselves. Critics like to be the first to know of a new talent. They like to be the inside dopsters who introduce that talent to the world.

Libeskind's reputation rose like a rocket with his victory at the World Trade Center, with no help from critics. And he's a very slick salesman of himself. He's charming, and he crafts himself into a personal brand or logo, with his black wrap-around glasses and cowboy boots. It's easy to dismiss him as a showman or a phony. Denver proves he isn't.

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